

phers in India and the grandiose studio portraits of Indian royals. His personal portraits and pictures of his family are like a yogi's gentle meditations in the hermitage of his household.

Umrao Singh often posed as his own subject. The earlier cameras and glass plate negatives required "enormous" exposure time of a few seconds. To fill that, he "performs" for the camera making tableaux of his aspirations—as a "Tolstoy-like" medieval scholar, a dandy prince or a long-haired ascetic. It is ironic that while he belonged to the bourgeois class and his pictures often bear the stamp of Victorian paintings and show influences of aristocratic mannerisms, yet they reveal an ease with his native and

**ARTIST'S FRAME:** Amrita poses with some of her paintings



Sikh cultural identity. He is equally comfortable posing with his bare body and non-turbaned self as much in formal outfits and tunics.

His family pictures also offer a rare and revealing insight into the life of Amrita—one of India's first modern artists—his elder daughter and favourite subject. The pictures reveal her early European influences, liberal upbringing and later quest for an identity in Indian cultural space. Her last pictures show a gentle shift from the formal rigidity of the posed photograph (with the advent of faster films replacing slow photographic processes) to poignant candid expressions—the eyes sheathing the tempests within. The book makes a well argued case to place the photographer Umrao Singh in the pantheon of Indian photographic history.

## TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

### FICTION

| NO.    | TITLE                     | AUTHOR         | PUBLISHER     |
|--------|---------------------------|----------------|---------------|
| 1. (1) | The 3 Mistakes of My Life | Chetan Bhagat  | Rupa          |
| 2. (2) | A Prisoner of Birth       | Jeffrey Archer | Pan Macmillan |
| 3. (3) | Brida                     | Paulo Coelho   | HarperCollins |
| 4. (5) | Sea of Poppies            | Amitav Ghosh   | Penguin       |
| 5. (4) | Unaccustomed Earth        | Jhumpa Lahiri  | Random House  |

### NON-FICTION

| NO.    | TITLE                   | AUTHOR                        | PUBLISHER          |
|--------|-------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------|
| 1. (1) | The Secret              | Rhonda Byrne                  | Atria              |
| 2. (-) | The Greatness Guide 2   | Robin S. Sharma               | Jaico              |
| 3. (2) | The Last Lecture        | Randy Pausch & Jeffrey Zaslow | Hodder & Stoughton |
| 5. (-) | Cold Steel              | Tim Bouquet and Byron Ousey   | Little, Brown      |
| 6. (-) | The Post American World | Fareed Zakaria                | Penguin            |

### OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

#### FICTION

| NO.      | TITLE                       | AUTHOR                     | PUBLISHER     |
|----------|-----------------------------|----------------------------|---------------|
| 9. (13)  | A Case of Exploding Mangoes | Mohammed Hanif             | Random House  |
| 10. (14) | The Japanese Wife           | Kunal Basu                 | HarperCollins |
| 13. (10) | Shantaram                   | Gregory David Roberts      | Penguin       |
| 20. (-)  | The Palace of Illusions     | Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni | Picador       |

#### NON-FICTION

| NO.     | TITLE                                                            | AUTHOR          | PUBLISHER  |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|------------|
| 7. (-)  | Go Kiss The World                                                | Subroto Bagchi  | Penguin    |
| 8. (-)  | We Are Like That Only: Understanding The Logic of Consumer India | Rama Bijapurkar | Penguin    |
| 10. (-) | 101 Ways To Reach The Next Level                                 | Robin S. Sharma | Jaico      |
| 11. (7) | The Elephant, The Tiger and Cellphone                            | Shashi Tharoor  | Penguin    |
| 12. (-) | Clearing a Space                                                 | Amit Chaudhuri  | Black Kite |

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead